# Decode Your Trauma Seminar - Day 3 Recording Notes

📝 Decode Your Trauma - Day 3 Notes
🕒 Started at 9:31AM on 29 Apr 2026, lasted 31m

## Decode Your Trauma - Day 3

🗓️ 29 Apr, 2026
👥 Alex Howard

### Outline

### Day 3 Session Overview and Format

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- Day 3 of the Decode Your Trauma series focuses on why context is everything, the three core emotional needs, and how unmet needs impact the nervous system
- Live Q&A support is available throughout the session via a typed Q&A function, with trained therapeutic coaching team members responding to participant questions in real time
- Lifetime access to session recordings is available for purchase on this final day, including a detailed workbook, worksheets, and daily live Q&A sessions with Alex Howard
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### The ECHO Model Recap and Week Roadmap

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- Previously covered content addressed the events of trauma, including overt, covert, single, and multiple-event traumas occurring in both childhood and adulthood
- Today's session covers the context of trauma and the three core emotional needs, while tomorrow's session will address the maladaptive stress response and shifts in nervous system homeostasis
- The final day will explore outcomes such as anxiety, depression, self-esteem issues, relationship difficulties, chronic health issues, and addiction, alongside approaches to healing and nervous system reset
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### Why Context Is Everything in Trauma

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- Two individuals can experience the same event, such as parental divorce, and have entirely different outcomes depending on the context and support available to them
- Emotional resilience is determined by whether core emotional needs are met during and around those events
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- Core emotional needs are described as being as fundamental to emotional development as food, water, and oxygen are to physical development, and their absence shapes how individuals cope and struggle in adult life

## The Three Core Emotional Needs Overview

- Boundaries represent the ability to say yes or no to others and to oneself, forming the foundation of personal strength, discipline, and the capacity to set limits in adult life
- Safety, particularly in early childhood, is rooted in co-regulation with a caregiver whose regulated state allows the child to feel calm and secure, which later becomes the basis for adult self-regulation
- Love refers not to conditional approval based on achievement but to unconditional acceptance of who a person is, forming the foundation of self-esteem and self-worth

## The Core Emotional Need for Boundaries

- Healthy boundaries in childhood involve knowing where the edges are, having them maintained consistently and with care, and being encouraged to challenge oneself within those limits
- Boundaries can be harmful when they are excessively rigid and crushing, completely absent, or inconsistent due to caregiver personality disorders, addiction, or poorly managed mood conditions
- Encouraging children to take moderate risks, such as climbing trees, teaches them that they can handle challenges and builds belief in their own capacity
- In adult life, healthy boundaries manifest as the ability to commit to goals, stop unhealthy habits, follow through on decisions, and assert limits with others
- A generational swing has been observed where parents who experienced overly rigid boundaries have raised children with very few limits, contributing to increased neurosis, narcissism, and difficulty meeting life's challenges in those children as adults

## The Core Emotional Need for Safety

- Feeling physically and emotionally safe as a child is a subjective experience that does not always align with objective circumstances, and both dimensions matter equally
- Emotional safety involves having feelings attended to, being physically held and comforted, and having a caregiver who is present and regulated enough to provide co-regulation
- Self-regulation in adulthood, such as using controlled breathing during stressful moments, is a direct outcome of having received adequate co-

regulation in childhood
- Hyperattunement to perceived threats in adult life is a sign that the nervous system did not learn to feel safe and continues to react to dangers that may not be present

## The Core Emotional Need for Love

- Feeling loved as a child is distinct from being loved, and the absence of felt love can occur even when caregivers genuinely care deeply for the child
- A clinical example illustrates how a child sent to boarding school against his wishes was told his distress could not be communicated home, leading him to emotionally shut down as a survival strategy, with lasting consequences for his health decades later
- Love must be personal and attuned to each child's individual interests and inner world in order to be felt as genuine and meaningful
- In adult life, unmet love needs can manifest as difficulty receiving love from others, deflecting affection, or feeling unworthy of care despite love being present

## Meeting Core Emotional Needs in Adult Life

- Adults are no longer dependent on caregivers to meet their core emotional needs and can learn to cultivate boundaries, inner safety, and self-worth independently
- Healing does not require confronting caregivers about their failures, as this approach has been observed to cause more pain for all involved without producing meaningful resolution
- Two things can be simultaneously true, that caregivers loved their children and that those children did not receive what they needed, and validating one's experience does not require blaming others
- Inner resources such as strength, safety, and love are described as always present within individuals, with dysregulation being what disconnects people from accessing them

## Next Steps

- Participants are encouraged to complete the day's worksheet and the personalised Decode Your Trauma assessment tool to deepen their self-understanding
- The upcoming session will cover the maladaptive stress response, the importance of nervous system homeostasis, and the concept of cultivating a healing state
- Lifetime access to the full series, including the workbook and live Q&A

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sessions, remains available for those wishing to continue their learning
beyond the live sessions
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## Key Points

- Day 3 of Decode Your Trauma focuses on why context shapes trauma outcomes and how three core emotional needs—boundaries, safety, and love—determine emotional resilience.
- Trauma's lasting impact stems not from events alone but from unmet emotional needs during those events, which overload the nervous system and drive maladaptive responses.
- Two people can experience identical events, such as parental divorce, with vastly different outcomes depending on the support and context surrounding them.
- Boundaries—the ability to say yes or no to others and oneself—form the foundation of personal strength, discipline, and resilience when consistently and skillfully maintained.
- Inconsistent boundaries, whether caused by contrasting caregivers, personality disorders, or addiction, leave children unable to gauge expectations and undermine their sense of security.
- A generational overcorrection toward permissive parenting has been linked to increased neurosis, narcissism, and reduced capacity to handle life's challenges in young adults.
- Safety as a core need is rooted in childhood co-regulation—a caregiver's regulated state teaches the child to self-soothe, forming the basis for adult self-regulation.
- The distinction between feeling safe and being objectively safe is critical; a hyperattuned nervous system can perceive threats that are not present.
- Love as a core need is about being seen and valued for who one is, not for achievements—its absence, even when parents do love their child, can cause lasting emotional shutdown.
- Alex Howard illustrated this with a boarding school patient whose letter home was censored, forcing him to suppress emotions entirely—resulting in chronic illness decades later.
- Resolving trauma does not require confronting or blaming caregivers; the priority is internal recognition of unmet needs and learning to meet them as an adult.
- Two truths can coexist: caregivers can have genuinely loved a child while still failing to meet their core emotional needs.
- Inner resources for strength, safety, and love are never lost—dysregulation through maladaptive stress responses is what blocks access to them.

## Action Items

- [x] ~~N/A~~

## Themes

- Trauma as a childhood experience with lasting adult consequences

- The ECHO model: Events, Context, Homeostasis, and Outcomes
- Three core emotional needs: Boundaries, Safety, and Love
- Co-regulation in childhood as the foundation for adult self-regulation
- The difference between objective circumstances and subjective emotional experience
- Generational patterns in parenting styles and their unintended consequences
- Self-healing and cultivating inner resources in adulthood
- The distinction between validating feelings and blaming caregivers
- Nervous system dysregulation as a response to unmet emotional needs
- The role of personal strength, self-worth, and self-esteem in healing

## Quotes

- "The walls of defense that we built to keep ourselves safe become the walls of the prism that trap us in our adult lives." - Alex Howard
- "These emotional needs are as important to your emotional development as things like food, oxygen, water are to your physical development." - Alex Howard
- "Your feelings are always valid. But the story that we tell ourselves about the circumstances that created those feelings is often not the whole truth." - Alex Howard
- "Two things can simultaneously be true. Your caregivers, they loved you and they love you. And you didn't get what you need." - Alex Howard
- "These resources don't leave. We leave because we become dysregulated." - Alex Howard
- "It's not an absence of love. It's an absence of the strategy of what he needed." - Alex Howard